

Great Blue Lobelia

Lobelia siphilitica

Blue Cardinal Flower



QUALITIES

An upright wetland perennial 2 to 3 feet tall, with lance-shaped leaves on stiff vertical stems. From August into September it produces dense terminal spikes of two-lipped sky-blue tubular flowers — the showiest true-blue native bloom of late summer in Minnesota. Each flower has a distinctive pair of white striped throats that guide pollinators to the nectar. Self-seeds modestly in suitable conditions.

CARE

Moist to wet soil; tolerates average garden soil if watered. Full sun to part shade. Hardy to USDA Zone 4. Plant from 1-gallon stock in spring; do not let the root ball dry out during establishment. Mulch lightly in fall. Short-lived (3-5 year) but reliably self-seeds. Companion-plant with Cardinal Flower; the two species occasionally hybridize naturally to produce striking purple-blooming offspring.

HISTORY

The species name *siphilitica* reflects its (now-debunked) historical use as a treatment for syphilis among Indigenous peoples; the root contains alkaloids that are toxic in large doses but were used medicinally in small preparations. The species has been cultivated since the 17th century, when it was introduced to European gardens as one of the first North American plant exports. The rich blue color was sought-after when blue flowers were rare in European horticulture.

REASON TO BE

Great Blue Lobelia provides a critical late-summer nectar source for long-tongued bumblebees, who are strong enough to pry open the two-lipped flowers; smaller bees can't. Its August-September bloom fills the gap between midsummer Bergamot and fall asters. Planted alongside Cardinal Flower in a vegetated bioswale's moist slope, the red-and-blue pairing is one of the most striking color contrasts in the native flora — and supports both bee and hummingbird pollinators in one composition.